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Universidad EAFIT
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Citizenship: Colombian, Spanish

ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

2020– Professor of Economics (tenured), Universidad EAFIT
2025– Director, Centro de Valor Público—EAFIT’s applied policy research center, Universidad EAFIT
2019–20 Professor of Economics (untentured), Universidad EAFIT
2024 Visiting Scholar, UNU – World Institute for Development Economics Research, Helsinki
2023 Visiting Scholar, Interamerican Development Bank, Washington, DC
2022 Visiting Professor, University of Chicago Harris School of Public Policy, Chicago
2017–19 Postdoctoral Scholar, University of Chicago Harris School of Public Policy & Innovations for Poverty Action
2016–17 Doctoral Scholar, Innovations for Poverty Action
2016 Visiting Doctoral Student, University of Chicago Harris School of Public Policy

OTHER AFFILIATIONS

2026– Chair, AL CAPONE—América Latina Crime and Policy Network
2024– Non-Resident Senior Research Fellow, UNU – World Institute for Development Economics Research
2024– Affiliate, J-PAL—Crime and Violence Initiative
2020– Academic Member, Evidence in Governance and Politics (EGAP); Board Member
2016– Researcher, Innovations for Poverty Action

CONFERENCE ORGANIZATION

2027 Host, 20th Annual Conference of the International Society for the Study of Drug Policy (ISSDP), Universidad EAFIT, Medellín
2027 Host, AL CAPONE Annual Meeting, Universidad EAFIT, Medellín
2025 Host, EGAP 29 Meeting, Universidad EAFIT, Medellín
2023 Local host, 20th IEA World Congress, Medellín

EDUCATION

2014–18 Ph.D., Economics, Universidad de los Andes, Bogotá. Dissertation with distinction
2014–17 M.A., Economics, Universidad de los Andes, Bogotá
2011–12 M.A., Economics, Université catholique de Louvain, Louvain-la-Neuve. *Grande distinction*
2009–11 M.A., Business, Universidad EAFIT, Medellín
2002–07 B.A., Computer Science, Universidad EIA, Envigado

FIELDS OF STUDY

Economics of crime, Organized crime and criminal governance, Drug policy, Policing and criminal justice, Development economics, Political economy

PRIZES AND HONORS

- 2024 Medellín Investiga Prize, awarded every year to the best research project related to Medellín's most important development challenges
- 2020 Juan Luis Londoño Medal, awarded every two years to Colombians of 40 years or less for the impact of their research and policy work on the welfare of Colombians

BOOKS

- 2027 *Cocaína: Anatomía de un mercado prohibido*. Under contract, Penguin Random House Grupo Editorial. Expected publication 2027.
- Forth. *State-building and State Capacity in Conflict-Affected Contexts: The Role of Formal and Informal Taxation*, edited with Patricia Justino, Zachariah Mampilly, Gauthier Marchais, and Anna D'Souza. Oxford University Press, in production.

ACADEMIC PUBLICATIONS

Journal Articles

- 2027 "Organized Crime and Violence," with Maria Micaela Sviatschi and Nicolás Cabra-Ruiz, forthcoming at *Annual Review of Economics*.
- 2026 "Implementation Outcomes of a CBT-Based Psychosocial Intervention for Gang-Recruitment-Vulnerable Youth in Medellín: A Qualitative Study of Novice Provider Experiences," with Mariantonia Lemos, Gabriela Algarín, and Martín Vanegas-Arias, *Cambridge Prisms: Global Mental Health* 13: e174.
- 2026 "State-building in the City: An Experiment in Civilian Alternatives to Policing," with Christopher Blattman, Gustavo Duncan, and Benjamin Lessing, forthcoming at *American Political Science Review*.
- 2025 "Gang Rule: Understanding and Countering Criminal Governance," with Christopher Blattman, Gustavo Duncan, and Benjamin Lessing, *Review of Economic Studies* 92(3): 1497–1531.
- 2023 "Production and Persistence of Criminal Skills: Evidence from a High-Crime Context," with Maria A. Escobar and Martín Vanegas-Arias, *Journal of Development Economics* 160: 102969.
- "The Perils of Military Policing," (invited commentary), *Nature Human Behaviour*.
- 2022 "Do Better Prisons Reduce Recidivism? Evidence from a Prison Construction Program," *The Review of Economics and Statistics* 104(6): 1256–1272.
- 2021 "Place-Based Interventions at Scale: The Direct and Spillover Effects of Policing and City Services on Crime," with Christopher Blattman, Donald Green, and Daniel Ortega, *Journal of the European Economic Association* 19(4): 2022–2051.
- "Hot Spots Policing in a High-Crime Environment: An Experimental Evaluation in Medellín," with Daniel Collazos, Eduardo García, Daniel Mejía, and Daniel Ortega, *Journal of Experimental Criminology* 17(3): 473–506.

- "The Deterrent Effect of Surveillance Cameras on Crime," with Santiago Gómez and Daniel Mejía, *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management* 40(2): 553–571.
- "Crises Conducting Stakeholder Salience: Shifts in the Evolution of Private Universities' Governance in Latin America," with M.A. Gonzalez-Perez, M. Cordova, M. Hermans, K.M. Nava-Aguirre, F. Monje-Cueto, S. Mingo, C.A. Rodriguez, E.H. Salvaj, and D.E. Floriani, *Corporate Governance: The International Journal of Business in Society* 21(6): 1194–1214.
- "Community Policing in the Developing World," (invited commentary), *Science* 374(6571): 1046–1047.
- 2020 "Meta-Analysis of Hematopoietic Stem Cell Transplantation in Major Histocompatibility Complex Class II Deficiency," with L.M. Castaño-Jaramillo, J. Bareño-Silva, and A.F. Escobar-Gonzalez, *Pediatric Transplantation* 24(6): e13774.
- 2018 "The Role of Land Property Rights in the War on Illicit Crops: Evidence from Colombia," with Juan Carlos Muñoz-Mora and Jesse W. d'Anjou, *World Development* 103: 268–283.
- Book Chapters*
- Forth. "Concealed Costs: Illicit Economies and the Erosion of the Local Tax Base in Colombia," with Patricia Justino, Martín Vanegas-Arias, and Juan F. Vargas, in *State-building and State Capacity in Conflict-Affected Contexts*, P. Justino et al., Eds., Oxford University Press.
- 2023 "Crime: Economics of, the Standard Approach," with Paolo Buonanno and Juan F. Vargas, in *Encyclopedia of Law and Economics*, A. Marciano and G.B. Ramello, Eds., Springer; updated edition 2026.
- 2022 "Prisons," with Paolo Buonanno and Juan F. Vargas, in *Encyclopedia of Law and Economics*, A. Marciano and G.B. Ramello, Eds., Springer.
- "Broken Windows Policing and Crime: Evidence from 80 Colombian Cities," with Daniel Mejía, Elkin Norza, and Martín Vanegas-Arias, in *A Modern Guide to the Economics of Crime*, P. Buonanno, P. Vanin, and J. Vargas, Eds., Edward Elgar Publishing, pp. 55–87.
- Policy Notes and Reports*
- 2026 "The Producer's Cut: Sizing Colombia's Cocaine Economy," with Daniel Mejía, Valor Público, Universidad EAFIT.
- "Construcción de Estado en la ciudad: lecciones de un experimento en alternativas civiles a la policía de Medellín," with Christopher Blattman, Gustavo Duncan, and Benjamin Lessing, Valor Público, Universidad EAFIT.
- "Beneficios jurídicos en juego: la Paz Total y el voto en territorios de grupos armados," with Michael Weintraub, Valor Público, Universidad EAFIT.
- "Beyond the Mine: Sizing Colombia's Illegal Gold Economy," Valor Público, Universidad EAFIT.
- 2024 "Gobierno de pandillas: entendiendo y contrarrestando la gobernanza criminal," with Christopher Blattman, Gustavo Duncan, and Benjamin Lessing, Valor Público, Universidad EAFIT.

- 2023 "Building Trust in State Actors: A Multi-Site Experiment with the Colombian National Police," with Verónica Abril, Erynn Norza, Santiago Pérez-Vincent, and Michael Weintraub, IDB Technical Note IDB-TN-2790.
- 2022 "The Terrible Trade-Off: Why Governments Must Choose between More Violence or Stronger Gangs," with Christopher Blattman and Benjamin Lessing, Modern War Institute at West Point.
- "Measuring Organised Crime: Challenges and Solutions for Collecting Data on Armed Illicit Groups," with Christopher Blattman, Benjamin Lessing, and Juan Pablo Mesa-Mejía, SOC ACE Briefing Note 3.
- "The Terrible Trade-Off: How the Hidden Cost of Organised Crime Harms Cities, and What Can Be Done about It," with Christopher Blattman and Benjamin Lessing, SOC ACE Briefing Note 4.
- 2020 "Crime Trajectories in Times of COVID-19: The Case of Colombia," with Nathalie Alvarado, Erynn Norza, Santiago Pérez-Vincent, and Martín Vanegas-Arias, IDB Technical Report 2034.
- "Crime in the Time of COVID-19," with Christopher Blattman, David Cerero, Gustavo Duncan, et al., EDI Report, COVID-19 Essay Series.
- 2018 "What Works to Prevent Violence among Youth? A White Paper on Youth Violence, Crime Prevention and the Mexican Context," with Thomas Abt, Christopher Blattman, and Beatriz Magaloni, USAID Report.
- 2016 "Sector Wide Impact Assessment on Human Rights: Mining Unseen," with Luis Fernando De Angulo, Camila Miranda, et al., Institute for Human Rights and Business Report.

WORKING PAPERS & PAPERS UNDER REVIEW

- "The Prohibition Trap: Rents, Violence, and Welfare in the Global Cocaine Chain," with Juan F. Vargas and Michael Weintraub
- "Education and Youth-Development Interventions for Organized-Crime Prevention in Developing Countries: Evidence, Extrapolation, and Policy," with Martín Vanegas-Arias. Revise and resubmit, *World Development*
- "From Schools of Crime to Criminal Hubs? Prisons and Organized Crime in Latin America and the Caribbean," with Ernesto Schargrofsky. Under review
- "Respect, Neutrality, and Police Legitimacy: A Representative Vignette Experiment in Post-Conflict Colombia," with Verónica Abril, Santiago Pérez-Vincent, and Martín Vanegas-Arias. Revise and resubmit, *Justice Quarterly*
- "Votes Follow Stakes: Peace Negotiations and Electoral Shifts in Armed-Group Territories," with Michael Weintraub. Under review
- "Who Joins Drug-Selling Gangs and Why? Beliefs and Recruitment Risk among 10,000 Adolescent Boys," with Christopher Blattman and Arantxa Rodríguez-Urbe
- "Pax Criminalis," with Christopher Blattman, Gustavo Duncan, Benjamin Lessing, and Juan F. Martínez
- "Gangs of Medellín: How Organized Crime Is Organized," with Christopher Blattman, Gustavo Duncan, and Benjamin Lessing
- "Building Trust in State Actors: A Multi-Site Experiment with the Colombian National Police," with Verónica Abril, Erynn Norza, Santiago Pérez-Vincent, and Michael Weintraub

“How Illegal Income Improves Schooling: Cocaine Production and Education in Colombia,” with Ivonne Lara, Martín Vanegas-Arias, and Juan Vargas

“Do Illegal Economies Reduce Local Fiscal Capacity?” with Patricia Justino, Martín Vanegas-Arias, and Juan Vargas

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Teaching

- 2019– Universidad EAFIT: Microeconomics Seminar—Economics of Crime (undergraduate); Microeconomics Seminar—Development Economics (undergraduate); Political Economy (undergraduate); Impact Evaluation (graduate)
- 2022 University of Chicago Harris School of Public Policy: Economic Development and Policy (graduate); International Police Reform Policy Lab (graduate)
- 2016– National Police of Colombia (lecturer): Evidence Based Policing (graduate-equivalent)
- 2017–19 American University (lecturer): Policing in the Global Context (undergraduate)
- 2015 Universidad de los Andes (teaching assistant): Economic Theory of Crime (graduate)

PhD Students

- 2023– Martín Vanegas-Arias, Universidad EAFIT (supervision)
- 2020–26 César Herrera, Universidad EAFIT (supervision; graduated 2026)
- 2022 PierFrancesco Rolla, University of Sussex (examination)
- 2021 Magaly Herrera, Universidad ICESI (examination)

Refereeing

Science, Nature, Quarterly Journal of Economics, American Political Science Review, AER: Insights, Review of Economics and Statistics, Journal of the European Economic Association, AEJ: Applied, Economic Journal, Journal of Labor Economics, Journal of Development Economics, Journal of Human Resources, Journal of Public Economics, Comparative Political Studies, Journal of Financial and Quantitative Analysis, Nature Human Behavior, Economic Development and Cultural Change, Defence and Peace Economics, Journal of Policy Analysis and Management, Criminology, Journal of Quantitative Criminology, Journal of Experimental Criminology, Criminology and Public Policy

SELECTED PRESENTATIONS

Conference and Seminar Presentations

- 2026 CAF Research Seminar, Buenos Aires; Universidad de San Andrés Economics Seminar, Buenos Aires; Universidad de Montevideo Economics Seminar; University of Chicago Harris School of Public Policy; Universidad EAFIT Economics Seminar; U.S. Department of State TIP Office–IPA Human Trafficking Research Initiative briefing (virtual); CAF Workshop with the Laboratorio de Justicia y Política Criminal, Cali
- 2025 UNU-WIDER Tax and Conflict Workshop, Helsinki; The Interconnection of Latin American Policy Challenges, Columbia University, New York; Empirical Studies of Conflict (ESOC) Annual Meeting, Taipei; AL CAPONE/RIDGE May Forum, Universidad del Pacífico, Lima; University of Chicago Development Economics Seminar; EGAP 29, Universidad EAFIT, Medellín

- 2024 UNU-WIDER Research Seminar, Helsinki; University of Chicago and LSE Conference on the Economics of Crime and Justice, London; AL CAPONE, Harvard University; EGAP 28, Paris; EGAP Regional Meeting, Rio de Janeiro; Drug Policy Forum, Universidad EAFIT; USAID Latin America Evidence Summit (virtual); UNU-WIDER meeting, New York; World Bank meeting, Bogotá
- 2023 IEA World Congress, Medellín; IDB Research Seminar, Washington, DC; UNU-WIDER Development Conference, Oslo; NBER Summer Institute: Crime, Cambridge, MA; Texas Economics of Crime Conference, Austin, TX; Seminario CAF; AL CAPONE/RIDGE, Montevideo; Empirical Studies of Conflict, Bogotá
- 2022 American Economics Association Annual Meeting; National Academies Workshop on Building Trust and Legitimacy in Policing; UNU-WIDER Development Conference, Bogotá; American Society of Criminology Annual Meeting, Atlanta; AL CAPONE, Reggio Calabria; UNU-WIDER Puzzle of Peace Conference, Helsinki; CLEAN Seminar; Urban Violence and Collective Memory in the Americas, Geneva; Conference on Criminal Governance, Rio de Janeiro; CIDE Lecture Series on Drug Policy
- 2021 Niskanen Center Panel Series on Violence Prevention; RIDGE Forum: AL CAPONE; Fedesarrollo; UNODC INEGI Conference on Governance, Crime and Justice Statistics; USAID; Center for Global Development Violence Prevention seminar; University of Chicago and LSE Conference on the Economics of Crime and Justice; Universidad Católica de Uruguay Economics Seminar; Congreso Anual Red de Investigadores de Economía
- 2020 BREAD/CEPR/STICERD/TCD Conference on Development Economics; Sao Paulo School of Economics; CEPR RPN on Preventing Conflict; University of Chicago Crime Lab; Empirical Studies of Conflict (ESOC); Texas Economics of Crime Workshop, College Station; Latin America Peace Science, Medellín
- 2019 Annual Colombian Economics Conference, Bogotá; IDB Innovation in Citizen Services Division, Washington, DC; LACEA, Puebla; Universidad EAFIT; What Works Global Summit, México D.F.; REDESAL, México D.F.; Behavioral Insights in Development and Peace Building, Göttingen; Economic Development and Institutions Annual Conference, Paris; Ministério Público do Estado do Rio de Janeiro; RIDGE Forum: Political Economy Workshop, Medellín; AL CAPONE, Medellín; Cities and Development Workshop, Johns Hopkins SAIS, Washington, DC; International Republican Institute, Panamá; Seminario CEDE CESED, Bogotá
- 2018 Encuentro Internacional de Observatorios del Delito, Policía Nacional, Bogotá; Households in Conflict Network Workshop, Medellín; Escuela de Posgrados de la Policía Nacional, Bogotá; Proantioquia, Medellín
- 2017 LACEA, Buenos Aires; Economic Development and Institutions Annual Conference, Namur; Economics of Organized Crime, Bogotá; Seminario de Economía, Banco de la República, Medellín; AL CAPONE, Santiago; Empirical Studies of Conflict, Washington, DC; EGAP 20, Bogotá; Seminario CEDE, Universidad de los Andes, Bogotá; National Network for Safe Communities, Tarrytown, NY; Seminario de Economía, Universidad del Rosario, Bogotá
- 2016 Center for Latin American Studies, Stanford; LACEA, Medellín; University of Chicago Crime Lab; AL CAPONE, Buenos Aires; American Law and Economics Association, Harvard Law School; Seminario Banco de la República, Bogotá
- 2015 LACEA, Santa Cruz de la Sierra

2014	LACEA, Sao Paulo; Seminario de Economía, Banco de la República, Bogotá
2012	Economías criminales y poder político, Universidad EAFIT, Medellín

GRANTS

2026–	Templeton World Charity Foundation, “Women at Risk: Understanding and Preventing Gang Involvement among Girls in Medellín,” \$250,000
2026–27	J-PAL Crime and Violence Initiative, “Parceritos: Second-Cohort Evaluation of a Community-Based Program for At-Risk Adolescents in Medellín,” \$124,000
2024–26	National Science Foundation (via University of Chicago), Medellín gang-recruitment field experiment and surveys, \$1,300,000
2025–26	University of Birmingham, policy interventions to reduce organized crime in Cali and Medellín, £49,253
2024–27	Wellspring Philanthropic Fund, Medellín organized-crime research agenda (behavioral prevention in schools, anti-extortion experiment, city-wide organized-crime survey), \$600,000
2025–26	The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics, “Understanding Gang Entry and Exit in Medellín, Colombia,” \$130,000
2024–25	Minerva Research Initiative, U.S. Department of Defense, “Youth Recruitment into Criminal Organizations in Latin America,” \$2,200,000. Award terminated by the funder in the 2025 U.S. federal grant cancellations
2024–25	USAID Development Innovation Ventures, “Countering Criminal Youth Recruitment,” \$199,802. Award terminated by the funder in the 2025 U.S. federal grant cancellations
2023–24	Innovations for Poverty Action, Human Trafficking Research Initiative (U.S. Department of State), “Understanding Gang Entry and Exit in Medellín, Colombia,” \$175,000
2022–24	Sistema General de Regalías, Gobierno de Colombia, “Estudios sobre pandillas, crimen urbano y gobierno criminal en Antioquia,” \$840,000
2022–23	Templeton World Charity Foundation, “Childhood Adversity, Misperceptions, and Gang Recruitment,” \$235,000
2022	Towards Kindness, “Understanding Gang Entry and Exit in Medellín, Colombia,” \$200,000
2021–23	Ministerio de Ciencia, Tecnología e Innovación, “Crimen urbano y políticas de seguridad en Colombia y América Latina: Reclutamiento, gobierno criminal y policía militarizada,” \$400,000
2022	Interamerican Development Bank, “Building Trust in State Actors: A Multi-Site Experiment with the Colombian National Police,” \$130,000
2020–21	Innovations for Poverty Action Peace and Recovery Program, “Gang Entry and Exit: Behavioral Biases and Gang Recruitment,” \$50,000
	Becker Friedman Institute, University of Chicago, “COVID-19, Crises, and Support for the Rule of Law: Organized Crime in Rio de Janeiro’s Favelas,” \$35,000
	Foreign and Commonwealth Office, UK, “How Organized Crime Is Responding to the COVID-19 Crisis,” \$35,000
	Universidad EAFIT, “Organized Crime in Rio de Janeiro: Understanding Non-State Provision of Order and Justice,” \$40,000

2020	J-PAL Crime and Violence Initiative, "The Other Virus: How Gangs and Organized Crime Are Responding to the COVID-19 Crisis," \$50,000
2020–23	Universidad EAFIT, "Improving Human Decisions through Machine Learning: An Experiment to Reduce Crime by Selecting Inmates Better," \$100,000
2019–20	National Science Foundation, SES 1919399, "Contesting Criminal Gang Governance in Medellín: Experimental Impacts of Intensive Municipal Governance and Community Organization on Gang Governance," \$375,000
2019	J-PAL Crime and Violence Initiative, "Contesting Criminal Gang Governance in Medellín," \$100,000
	Fundación para el Desarrollo de Antioquia – Proantioquia, "Gangs of Medellín: A Proposal to Map Order and Violence at the Micro Level," \$70,000
2018	Secretaría de Seguridad de Medellín, "Gangs of Medellín: A Proposal to Map Order and Violence at the Micro Level," \$33,000
	Proantioquia, "Gangs of Medellín: A Proposal to Map Order and Violence at the Micro Level," \$70,000
2017–18	J-PAL Latin America and Caribbean, "Strategies and Programs to Prevent Violence among Youth," \$32,000
	Economic Development and Institutions – EDI, "Gangs of Medellín: A Proposal to Understand Variation in Non-State Provision of Order and Justice," \$100,000
	CESED/Postobon, Universidad de los Andes, "Gangs of Medellín," \$10,000
	CESED/Open Society Foundations, Universidad de los Andes, "Gangs of Medellín," \$10,000
2016–17	Development Priorities Window – 3ie, "Increasing State and Police Presence in the Least Governed Areas of Bogotá: A Hot Spot Policing Approach," \$280,000
	J-PAL Governance Initiative, "State-Building on the Intensive and Extensive Margins: Testing Urban Violence Reduction through Policing and Public Services in Bogotá," \$360,000
	CAF – Development Bank of Latin America, "The Impact of Hotspot Policing and Municipal Services on Crime: Experimental Evidence from Bogotá," \$50,000
	Government Partnership Initiative – J-PAL, "The Impact of Hotspot Policing and Municipal Services on Crime: Experimental Evidence from Bogotá," \$20,000
2016	CESED/Postobon, Universidad de los Andes, "Prison Overcrowding and Recidivism: Evidence from Colombia," \$10,000
	CESED/Open Society Foundations, Universidad de los Andes, "El Sistema de Justicia Criminal en la lucha contra el consumo de drogas ilícitas," \$10,000

PUBLIC WRITING AND MEDIA

2015–	Public writing on crime, policing, prisons, and drug policy in VoxDev, UNU-WIDER, Foco Económico, Nada es Gratis, Razón Pública, La Silla Vacía, and the Inter-American Development Bank's Sin Miedos blog
	Commentary and analysis in Colombian media, including El Colombiano, El Espectador, and Caracol Radio's Hora 20 panel
	Research coverage in <i>The Economist</i> , El Tiempo, Portafolio, El Colombiano, El Espectador, Infobae, Noticias RCN, BluRadio, and El Universal, among others

Podcast appearances: Probable Causation (Ep. 61), The Visible Hand, Atemporal, Stories of Impact

POLICY POSITIONS AND CONSULTING

2021–22	Consultant, Police Reform, National Police of Colombia Consultant, Policy Analysis and Evaluation, Federación Nacional de Departamentos Consultant, Impact Evaluation, Fundación Acción Interna
2020–21	Consultant, Human Rights, Human Rights Office, Presidency of Colombia Consultant, Human Trafficking, International Organization for Migration
2019–23	Consultant, Innovation in Citizen Services Division, Inter-American Development Bank
2019	Advisor to the Director for Justice, Security and Government, National Planning Department
2018–19	Advisor on Monitoring and Evaluation, International Organization for Migration
2017–18	Advisor to the Deputy Minister for Crime Policy, Ministry of Justice of Colombia Advisor to the Secretary, Secretariat of Security of Bogotá
2017	Consultant, Innovation in Citizen Services Division, Inter-American Development Bank
2015–16	Consultant, CAF – Latin American Development Bank Consultant, CREER-IHRB Institute for Human Rights and Business
2014–15	Chief of Staff, Senator in the 4th Committee on Economic Affairs, Colombian Congress
2013–14	Advisor, FINAGRO – Rural Development Bank, Colombia
2009–11	Director, Cadastre and Territorial Development, Government of Antioquia, Colombia
2008–09	Director, Economic Development, Government of Antioquia, Colombia